Assignment 1: How Matrix Size Affects the Runtime and Memory of Basic Matrix Multiplication in Python, Java and C

Daniel Perdomo Medina
Big Data — Grado en Ciencia e Ingeniería de Datos, ULPGC, 2026–2027

Code, data and instructions: `https://github.com/Perdomin38/matmul-basic-benchmark`

October 2026

Abstract

This study asks how the matrix size n affects the runtime and the memory use of the same textbook $O(n^3)$ matrix multiplication written in Python, Java and C. The three implementations use the same triple loop (i–j–k order), the same float64 inputs read from shared files, and they were validated against known answers and against NumPy before benchmarking. On one laptop (Intel Core i7-13620H, Windows 11), sizes $n = 100, 200, \ldots, 3200$ were attempted; every configuration that finished within the 600 s budget (up to $n = 1600$ for C and Java, $n = 800$ for Python) was run five times after warm-up, and the median, the interquartile range and the peak process memory were recorded. From $n = 100$ to 400 the runtime grew by 7.6 to 15.8 times per doubling of n (cubic model: 8 times), and by up to 54 times at larger sizes, so the cubic model holds only approximately. C was the fastest implementation at every tested size. Java took 1.2 to 1.6 times as long as C up to $n = 800$ but 6.5 times as long at $n = 1600$; a controlled re-run with cool-down pauses confirmed this jump. CPython took 87 to 162 times as long as C. These conclusions apply only to these implementations, settings and this machine.

1 Introduction and objective

Matrix multiplication is a basic building block of data science and machine learning, and its cost grows quickly with the size of the matrices. Before studying optimised, sparse, parallel and distributed versions in later assignments, this first study establishes a *baseline*: the simplest algorithm written in three widely used languages that execute code in very different ways (an interpreter, a JIT-compiling virtual machine and an ahead-of-time compiler).

Research question. *How does the matrix size n affect the runtime and the memory use of the basic triple-loop matrix multiplication implemented in Python, Java and C on one fixed machine?*

The factor that changes is n (side length of the $n \times n$ square matrices) and the implementation language; the outcomes are the multiplication time and the peak memory of the process.

Hypotheses (predictions made before measuring).

H1 Runtime grows approximately as n^3, i.e. about 8 times longer every time n doubles, for all three implementations.

H2 C and Java will be within a small factor of each other, and CPython will be one to two orders of magnitude slower, because it interprets every operation.

H3 Memory grows approximately as n^2 (three $n \times n$ matrices), with a constant runtime overhead that is largest for the JVM and with a larger per-element cost in Python, where every number is an object.

2 Background and references

Algorithm. For $C = AB$ with $A, B \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times n}$, each element is the dot product $c_{ij} = \sum_{k=0}^{n-1} a_{ik} b_{kj}$. Computing n^2 elements, each with n multiply–add operations, costs exactly n^3 multiplications and n^3 additions, so the work is $\Theta(n^3)$ [1]. Asymptotically faster algorithms exist (e.g. Strassen) but are out of scope; the assignment requires the straightforward triple loop.

Memory hierarchy. The time of a multiply–add depends on where its operands are: registers and caches are much faster than main memory [2]. In the i–j–k order, the inner loop reads a *row* of A (consecutive addresses, cache friendly) but a *column* of B (addresses $8n$ bytes apart, one cache line per element). When the matrices no longer fit in the caches, the cost per operation is expected to rise, so measured times can grow faster than the pure n^3 model.

Execution models. C is compiled ahead of time to machine code by GCC. Java is compiled to bytecode, which the HotSpot JVM first interprets and then compiles to machine code just-in-time (JIT) once a method is "hot"; this is why warm-up runs are needed [3]. CPython interprets bytecode and represents every float as a heap object, so every arithmetic operation involves type dispatch and object handling.

Benchmarking practice. Repeated measurements, warm-up, and robust summaries (median, interquartile range) are recommended because single measurements of modern systems are noisy [3, 4].

3 Methodology

3.1 Implementations

The three programs implement exactly the same loop (Listing 1), with a local accumulator and the same i–j–k order, using 64-bit IEEE-754 floating point (`double` in C and Java, `float` in Python). No optimised library is used inside any measured kernel.

Listing 1: Kernel shared by the three implementations (C version).

```
for (int i = 0; i < n; i++)
    for (int j = 0; j < n; j++) {
        double sum = 0.0;
        for (int k = 0; k < n; k++)
            sum += A[i * n + k] * B[k * n + j];
        C[i * n + j] = sum;
    }
```

Storage layouts (unavoidable language differences).

- **C**: one contiguous `malloc` block of n^2 doubles per matrix, row-major (`A[i*n+k]`); 8 bytes per element.
- **Java**: `double[n][n]`, an array of n row arrays. Each row is contiguous, but rows are separate heap objects, and each access `B[k][j]` first loads the reference to row `k` and is bounds-checked.
- **Python**: a list of n lists. Each list stores 8-byte pointers to separate `float` objects (24 bytes each in CPython), so about 32 bytes per element, possibly scattered in memory.

3.2 Inputs

For every n, the matrices A and B were generated once with NumPy (`default_rng(2026 + n)`, uniform values in $[-1, 1)$) and saved as binary files of little-endian float64 values in row-major order. All three programs read the same files, so they multiply exactly the same logical matrices and no cross-language random generator is involved. Declared size sequence: $n = 100, 200, 400, 800, 1600, 3200$; doubling n makes the expected cubic growth easy to check (8 times longer per step).

3.3 Environment and fixed settings

Item	Value
CPU	Intel Core i7-13620H: 6 performance + 4 efficiency cores, 16 logical CPUs 24 MB shared L3 cache [5]
RAM / OS	16 GB / Windows 11 Home (build 26200), laptop plugged in
C	GCC 16.2.0 (MinGW-w64 UCRT), flags `-O2 -std=c11 -static`
Java	Oracle JDK 24.0.1, HotSpot 64-bit Server VM, flag `-Xmx3g`
Python	CPython 3.11.9 (standard library only in the kernel)
Helper tools	NumPy 2.2.0 (inputs, reference), psutil 6.1.0 (memory), pandas, matplotlib
Threads	all kernels single-threaded; no numerical library inside the kernels

Table 1: Machine and toolchain. These settings were fixed for all runs.

The flag `-O2` is GCC's standard optimisation level; it was kept fixed and no architecture-specific (`-march=native`) or unsafe floating-point (`-ffast-math`) flags were used, so the compiler may not reorder the floating-point sum. `-static` only avoids a run-time DLL dependency. The JVM used its default JIT (tiered compilation) and garbage collector (G1); `-Xmx3g` caps the heap below the memory budget.

Because the CPU is hybrid, a first exploratory run (kept in `results/exploratory_unpinned/`) showed large run-to-run variation, e.g. five consecutive Python runs at $n = 200$ ranged from 0.67 s to 2.95 s, consistent with the operating system moving the process between fast and slow cores. In the final run every benchmark process was therefore pinned to the performance cores (logical CPUs 0–11) with high priority.

3.4 Timing protocol

- **Timed region**: only the multiplication kernel. Reading the input files and allocating the result matrix happen *before* the timer starts.
- **Timers**: monotonic clocks: `clock_gettime(CLOCK_MONOTONIC)` in C, `System.nanoTime()` in Java, `time.perf_counter()` in Python.
- **Warm-up**: C 1 run, Python 1 run (caches, page faults), Java 2 runs (JIT compilation). Warm-up runs are recorded in the raw data but excluded from the statistics.
- **Repetitions**: 5 measured runs per configuration, all in the same process. Reported: median and interquartile range (IQR $= Q_3 - Q_1$), plus min and max.
- **Result consumption**: after each run the program sums all elements of C (checksum) and prints it, so the computation cannot be skipped by the compiler; each checksum is compared with NumPy's result (relative tolerance 10^{-9}).

3.5 Memory measurement

The metric is the **peak resident memory of the whole process** (on Windows, the *peak working set*, a peak value kept by the operating system), read with psutil [6] every 10 ms by the benchmark script. It includes the language runtime (JVM, interpreter) and all data, not only the matrices. As a reference, the raw storage of three float64 matrices is $3 \times 8n^2$ bytes.

3.6 Budgets and limits

Before the large tests, a budget was declared per configuration (one language and one n, including warm-ups): **600 s of wall time** and **4096 MB of memory**. A configuration exceeding a budget is killed and recorded as TIMEOUT or MEMORY_LIMIT; larger sizes of that language are then recorded as SKIPPED. No execution time is invented for them.

3.7 Correctness checks

Before benchmarking, each implementation multiplied four test cases and wrote its result to a file: (1) a hand-computed 2×2 case $\left(\begin{smallmatrix}1&2\\3&4\end{smallmatrix}\right)\left(\begin{smallmatrix}5&6\\7&8\end{smallmatrix}\right) = \left(\begin{smallmatrix}19&22\\43&50\end{smallmatrix}\right)$; (2) $A \cdot I = A$ with $n = 37$; (3) $A \cdot 0 = 0$ with $n = 37$ (all three required *exact* equality); and (4) random A, B with $n = 100$ compared with NumPy's `A @ B`, accepted if $|c - c_{\text{ref}}| \leq 10^{-9} + 10^{-9}|c_{\text{ref}}|$ for every element. The tolerance is justified by the rounding-error bound of a dot product, $|\hat{c} - c| \leq \gamma_n \sum_k |a_{ik} b_{kj}|$ with $\gamma_n \approx nu$ and $u \approx 1.1 \times 10^{-16}$ [7]: for $n = 100$ and values in $[-1, 1)$ this is of order 10^{-13}, far below 10^{-9}, while an indexing bug would produce errors of order 1. NumPy sums in a different order (BLAS), so tiny differences are legitimate.

4 Results

4.1 Correctness

All implementations passed all tests (Table 2). The exact tests gave zero error. In the random test the maximum difference from NumPy was 5.3×10^{-15}, and the three implementations produced *bitwise identical* matrices, as expected since they perform the same operations in the same order with IEEE-754 doubles. During the benchmark, every checksum matched the NumPy reference.

Test	n	Criterion	Max abs. error (C, Java, Python)	Passed
known 2×2	2	exact	0, 0, 0	yes (all)
identity $A \cdot I$	37	exact	0, 0, 0	yes (all)
zero $A \cdot 0$	37	exact	0, 0, 0	yes (all)
random vs NumPy	100	rtol = atol = 10^{-9}	5.3×10^{-15} (each)	yes (all)

Table 2: Correctness tests (`results/raw/correctness.csv`).

4.2 Runtime

Table 3 summarises the five measured runs of every configuration that finished within budget; Figure 1 shows the medians on log–log axes.

Lang.	n	Median (s)	IQR (s)	IQR/median	ns per mult-add	Growth (times)
C	100	0.0002703	0.000011	4.0%	0.27	—
C	200	0.002717	0.000091	3.3%	0.34	10.1
C	400	0.03216	0.00018	0.6%	0.50	11.8
C	800	0.3357	0.0026	0.8%	0.66	10.4
C	1600	4.122	0.23	5.5%	1.01	12.3
Java	100	0.0004409	0.0000037	0.8%	0.44	—
Java	200	0.003361	0.000028	0.8%	0.42	7.6
Java	400	0.05294	0.0088	16.6%	0.83	15.8
Java	800	0.4976	0.058	11.6%	0.97	9.4
Java	1600	26.79	1.9	7.0%	6.54	53.8
Python	100	0.03706	0.0014	3.7%	37.06	—
Python	200	0.3091	0.0034	1.1%	38.64	8.3
Python	400	2.803	0.029	1.0%	43.80	9.1
Python	800	54.30	2.2	4.1%	106.06	19.4

Table 3: Multiplication time, 5 measured runs per row (warm-ups excluded). "ns per mult-add" = median/n^3; a constant value means perfect cubic scaling. "Growth" = median at n divided by median at $n/2$ (cubic model: 8). Source: `results/tables/runtime_summary.csv`.

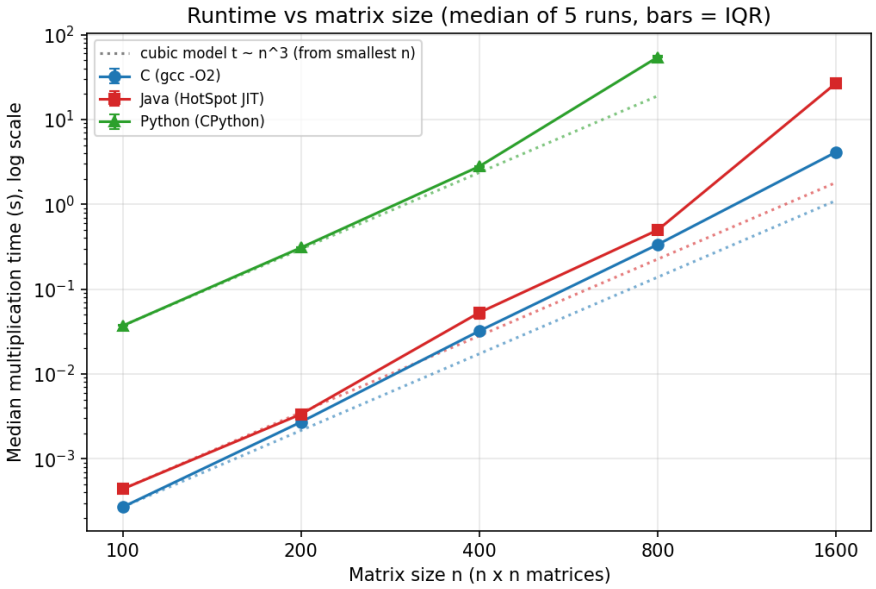


Figure 1: Median multiplication time versus n (log–log). Error bars show the IQR (mostly smaller than the markers). Dotted lines extrapolate each language's smallest-n time with the cubic model $t \propto n^3$.

Ratios of medians with respect to C: Java/C = 1.6, 1.2, 1.6, 1.5 and 6.5 for $n = 100$ to 1600, and Python/C = 137, 114, 87 and 162 for $n = 100$ to 800. Fitting $t = an^b$ to all completed sizes gives $b = 3.47$ (C), 3.90 (Java) and 3.47 (Python). Figure 2 shows the cost per inner-loop operation.

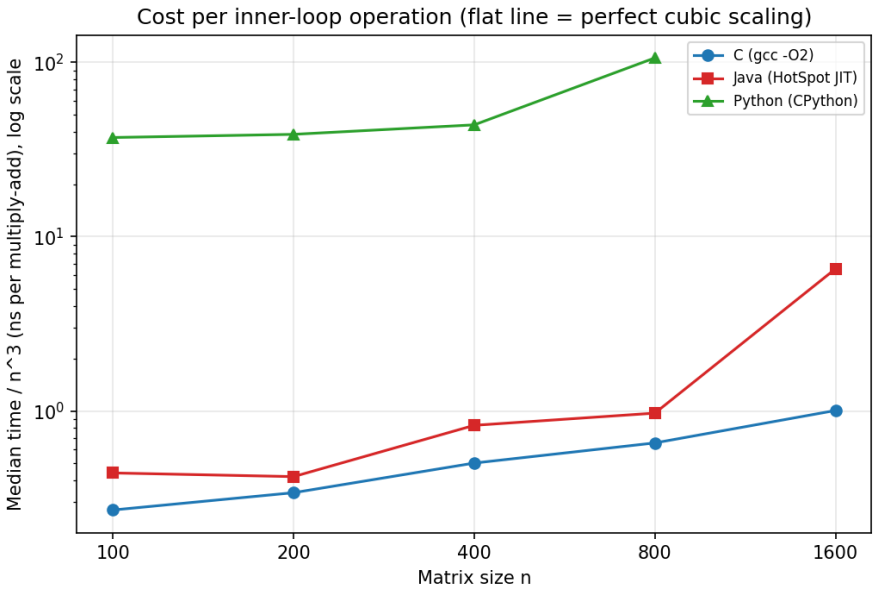


Figure 2: Median time divided by n^3 (nanoseconds per multiply–add). A flat line would mean exact cubic scaling; an increasing line means each operation becomes more expensive as the matrices grow.

Warm-up. For Java, the first warm-up run took 5.7 times ($n = 100$) and 2.4 times ($n = 200$) as long as the measured median, consistent with the JIT compiling the kernel during the first runs. From $n = 400$ the ratio was close to 1, since the JIT compiles the loop early inside the (longer) first run. For C and Python the first run was within 6% of the median (27% for C at $n = 100$, where a run lasts 0.3 ms).

4.3 Memory

n	C (MB)	Java (MB)	Python (MB)	$3 \times 8n^2$ bytes (MB)
100	9.1	43.0	16.5	0.23
200	9.0	46.5	20.3	0.92
400	11.8	52.5	33.8	3.66
800	22.8	75.0	89.6	14.65
1600	66.7	198.4	—	58.59

Table 4: Peak resident memory (peak working set) of the whole process, measured with psutil; MB $= 2^{20}$ bytes. Source: `results/tables/memory_summary.csv`.

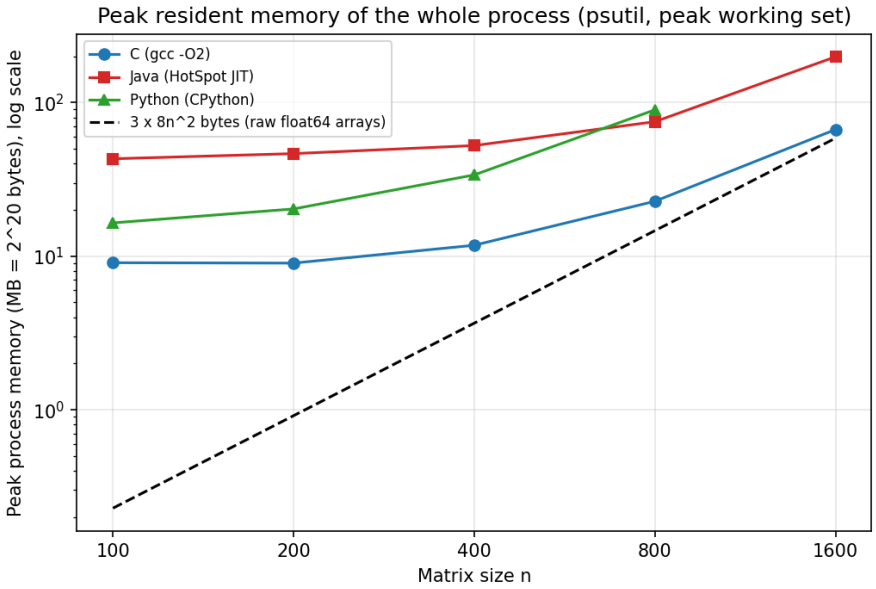


Figure 3: Peak process memory versus n (log–log). The dashed line is the raw storage of three float64 matrices.

4.4 Limits

Language	Largest feasible n	First size over budget	Outcome at larger sizes
C	1600	3200 (TIMEOUT after 600 s, peak 242.5 MB)	—
Java	1600	3200 (TIMEOUT after 600 s, peak 491.2 MB)	—
Python	800	1600 (TIMEOUT after 600 s, peak 311.7 MB)	3200 SKIPPED

Table 5: Largest size that met the 600 s / 4096 MB budget. No configuration reached the memory budget. Source: `results/raw/runs_status.csv`.

The timed-out configurations are not summarised, but the runs that completed before the limit are kept in the raw data: at $n = 3200$ a single C multiplication took about 252 s, at least 60 times the $n = 1600$ median (cubic model: 8 times); a Java warm-up run took 309 s; and at $n = 1600$ one Python warm-up run took 336 s.

5 Discussion

Answer to the question (H1). H1 is only partially supported. For small matrices the runtime grows roughly cubically: from $n = 100$ to 400 the time grows 8.3 and 9.1 times per doubling in Python, 10.1 and 11.8 in C, and 7.6 and 15.8 in Java (cubic model: 8). The cost per operation is not constant, however (Figure 2): for C it increases smoothly from 0.27 ns to 1.01 ns, so even for $n \leq 800$, where three C matrices fit in the 24 MB L3 cache, the fitted exponent of C and Java is 3.44, not 3 (3.47–3.90 over all completed sizes). The cubic model counts operations correctly, but it ignores how expensive each operation is, which depends on the memory system and on the machine.

Memory-layout effects. The sharpest changes appear when the working data outgrow the 24 MB L3 cache. Three matrices of $n = 800$ take 14.6 MB in C and Java, but about $3 \times 32 \times 800^2 \approx 61$ MB in Python; Python's cost per operation jumps from 43.8 ns to 106 ns exactly at $n = 800$ (part of this jump is due to sustained load, see the limitations below). At $n = 1600$ (58.6 MB of raw data) the cost per operation of Java jumps from 0.97 ns to 6.5 ns, whereas C, running the same loop on the same inputs, increases only from 0.66 ns to 1.01 ns. In the main benchmark the languages ran in a fixed order, so Java at $n = 1600$ started right after 600 s of C at $n = 3200$. A controlled check therefore repeated C and Java at $n = 1600$ in alternating processes, each after a 60 s cool-down (`results/raw/supplementary_cold_java_c_1600.txt`): Java's median was 25.3–26.9 s and C's 3.0 s, i.e. 8.4–8.9 times, so the jump is not caused by the run order or by heating. Because the algorithm and the inputs are the same, the most plausible cause is the storage layout: walking down a column of B in C uses addresses with a constant stride inside one block, which the hardware can predict, while in Java each step must first load a different row reference and the rows are separate objects. C shows a similar cliff only one size later (about 252 s at $n = 3200$, at least 60 times the time at $n = 1600$). These explanations are consistent with the evidence but were not confirmed with hardware counters (cache or TLB misses), so they remain hypotheses.

Interpreter and runtime effects (H2). H2 is supported up to $n = 800$, but not at $n = 1600$, where Java takes 6.5 times as long as C (see above). Up to $n = 800$ Java takes only 1.2 to 1.6 times as long as C: after JIT compilation both execute machine code, and the remaining gap is consistent with bounds checks and the extra row indirection. CPython takes 87 to 162 times as long as C (the 162 at $n = 800$ is inflated by sustained load; the fastest cold run gives about 95 times), because every `+` and `*` is executed by the interpreter on boxed `float` objects, which costs about 37–44 ns per multiply–add instead of below 1 ns. The JIT is also visible in Java's warm-up runs.

Memory (H3). H3 is supported. The runtime overhead dominates for small n: the JVM needs about 43 MB before the matrices matter, Python about 16 MB, C about 9 MB. For large n the growth follows n^2. C's increase from $n = 100$ to 1600 (57.6 MB) matches the raw storage (58.4 MB). Python's increase from $n = 100$ to 800 (73 MB for 1.92 million elements) is about 40 bytes per element, i.e. about 5 times the 8 bytes of a C double. A pointer plus a `float` object explain 32 bytes (4 times); the rest is consistent with the temporary buffers used while reading the input files (the raw bytes and the tuple returned by `struct.unpack`). Java at $n = 1600$ (198 MB) uses more than three times the raw storage; the JVM heap also holds the byte buffers used while reading the input files until the garbage collector reclaims them, and the heap grows in steps. Memory never limited the experiment: time did.

System effects and limitations.

- **One machine.** All results come from one laptop; with a hybrid CPU, unpinned runs were unreliable (Section 3.3), so pinning to performance cores was part of the protocol.
- **Sustained load.** A supplementary check (`results/raw/supplementary_sustained_load_check.txt`) ran the Python $n = 800$ case four times in a row: 31.9, 40.9, 43.4 and 57.2 s, independently of pinning. This is consistent with the laptop lowering its clock under sustained load (base power 45 W, maximum turbo power 115 W [5]); the frequency was not logged, so this is an inference. Long runs (large n) may therefore run at a lower clock, which can contribute to the increase of the cost per operation. Even the fastest of these runs (31.9 s) means about 62 ns per multiply–add for Python at $n = 800$, still above the 44 ns at $n = 400$. Java's jump at $n = 1600$ survived the controlled cool-down check.
- **Measurement design.** The five repetitions run inside one process and the configurations ran in a fixed order, so the IQR does not capture variation between processes [4]; Java at $n = 400$ and 800 showed 12–17% IQR. The 0.27 ms runs of C at $n = 100$ were not batched. The benchmark checksum is a sum of all elements, so the element-wise check is the one at $n = 100$ (Section 3.7).
- **Memory metric.** The peak working set includes the whole runtime; it is not comparable to an array-size estimate or to a managed-heap measurement.
- **Coarse size grid.** Doubling n cannot locate exactly where the cliffs start.

6 Conclusions

Within the tested scope (these three basic implementations, i–j–k order, float64, GCC `-O2`, HotSpot JDK 24, CPython 3.11, one i7-13620H laptop with pinning to performance cores):

- The cubic model describes the runtime only approximately (H1 partially supported): from $n = 100$ to 400 the time grew 7.6 to 15.8 times per doubling instead of 8, and much faster at larger sizes; the operation count alone does not predict the time.
- C was the fastest at every size; CPython was about two orders of magnitude slower than C.
- Java took at most 1.6 times as long as C up to $n = 800$, but 6.5 times as long at $n = 1600$ (H2 holds only up to $n = 800$). A controlled re-run with alternating processes and cool-down pauses gave 8.4–8.9 times, so this jump is a real property of the Java implementation on this machine, not an effect of the run order or of heating. Its most plausible (unconfirmed) cause is Java's array-of-rows layout, which makes walking down a column of B much more expensive once the matrices outgrow the caches.
- Memory grows as n^2 plus a runtime-dependent constant; Python needs about 5 times more memory per element than C.
- The largest feasible sizes under the 600 s budget were $n = 1600$ (C, Java) and $n = 800$ (Python).

This study does not show that one language is universally faster: the gap depends on the size, on the storage layout and on the machine. What remains unresolved is the exact cause of the large-n cliffs (cache versus TLB misses, and for Python also the clock frequency), which would require hardware counters and frequency logging; optimised loop orders and storage layouts are left for Assignment 2.

Reproducibility materials

Code, raw data (CSV), analysis scripts and exact instructions are in the repository `https://github.com/Perdomin38/matmul-basic-benchmark` (see `README.md`). All fixed settings are in `scripts/common.py`. The pipeline (run from `scripts/`) is:

`build.py` → `generate_inputs.py` → `verify.py` → `run_benchmarks.py` → `analyze.py`

Raw measurements: `results/raw/benchmark_raw.csv` (every warm-up and measured run) and `results/raw/runs_status.csv`.

Use of AI tools

An AI assistant (Claude, Anthropic) was used to help plan the experimental design, write and debug the scripts, and revise the English of this report. All measurements were obtained by running the code on the machine described above, and the author has checked the code, the results and the references and is responsible for the conclusions.

References

[1] G. H. Golub and C. F. Van Loan, *Matrix Computations*, 4th ed. Baltimore, MD, USA: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2013.

[2] U. Drepper, "What every programmer should know about memory," Red Hat, Inc., Tech. Rep., Nov. 2007. [Online]. Available: `https://people.freebsd.org/~lstewart/articles/cpumemory.pdf`. Accessed: Oct. 15, 2026.

[3] A. Georges, D. Buytaert, and L. Eeckhout, "Statistically rigorous Java performance evaluation," in *Proc. 22nd ACM SIGPLAN Conf. Object-Oriented Programming Systems, Languages and Applications (OOPSLA)*, 2007, pp. 57–76.

[4] T. Kalibera and R. Jones, "Rigorous benchmarking in reasonable time," in *Proc. 2013 Int. Symp. Memory Management (ISMM)*, 2013, pp. 63–74.

[5] Intel Corporation, "Intel Core i7-13620H processor (24M cache, up to 4.90 GHz): Specifications." [Online]. Available: `https://www.intel.com/content/www/us/en/products/sku/232130/intel-core-i713620h-processor-24m-cache-up-to-4-90-ghz/specifications.html`. Accessed: Oct. 15, 2026.

[6] G. Rodola, "psutil documentation," version 6.1.0. [Online]. Available: `https://psutil.readthedocs.io`. Accessed: Oct. 15, 2026.

[7] N. J. Higham, *Accuracy and Stability of Numerical Algorithms*, 2nd ed. Philadelphia, PA, USA: SIAM, 2002.